

COLLECTION · BUYERS

Buying New vs. Existing Property

*New construction, GCR warranty and resale
homes — how to choose well*

READ BEFORE YOU BEGIN

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Buying New vs. Existing Property

New construction, GCR warranty and resale homes — how to choose well

New or existing? Both have their strengths. New appeals through its warranty, energy efficiency and “nothing to renovate”; existing through its charm, established location and sometimes a better space-to-price ratio. This guide helps you choose with full knowledge.

You'll understand the Residential Construction Warranty (GCR), the specifics of buying off-plan, the timelines and deposits, and the checks specific to each option.

Each chapter ends with a lined “My notes” page to compare your options.

New or existing: it's not just a matter of taste, but of warranty, budget and tolerance for surprises. This guide compares the two honestly — costs, warranties, off-plan purchase, checks — for an informed choice.

The benchmarks (2026 edition) are there to explain the logic; confirm the warranty and financing details with the relevant professionals.

CHAPTER

New vs existing: the real matchup

Weighing the advantages and trade-offs of each option.

New

- Advantages: warranty, recent standards, energy efficiency, customization, little maintenance at the start.
- Trade-offs: often more expensive per square foot, developing neighbourhoods (services to come), delivery timelines, taxes applicable to new construction.

Existing

- Advantages: established locations, charm, mature trees, sometimes more space for the price.
- Trade-offs: maintenance and renovations, systems to modernize, possible surprises (hence the inspection).

Beyond taste, think resale and total cost: new costs more per square foot but starts with no surprises; existing is often cheaper to buy but requires a renovation budget. The right choice depends on your tolerance for surprises and the time you want to spend on maintenance.

EMILIE'S TIP

Don't just compare prices: compare the total cost over 5 years, maintenance and energy included. A “cheaper” existing home can cost more with a roof and windows to redo.

CHAPTER

The Residential Construction Warranty (GCR)

Understanding what a new home's warranty covers.

In Quebec, most eligible new homes (including many condos and houses) are covered by a mandatory warranty plan administered by Garantie de construction résidentielle (GCR). It protects the buyer against certain defects and failures by the builder, according to defined durations and caps.

- Deposit protection and completion of the work in the event of the builder's default.
- Coverage of defects and poor workmanship over increasing durations (short deadlines for apparent defects up to several years for major defects).
- Exclusions and conditions exist: read the warranty contract.

2026 edition note: the terms and the plan's administrator may change; confirm the coverage applicable to YOUR purchase with the builder and the notary.

The GCR covers in stages: deposit and completion at acceptance, then latent defects and major defects over longer periods (generally up to 5 years for major defects). It comes with limits and exclusions: read the warranty contract and keep your acceptance documents.

EMILIE'S TIP

Require proof of the warranty's registration and read what it covers BEFORE signing. A beautiful new unit without a warranty in good standing is a risk not to take.

CHAPTER

Buying off-plan: timelines, deposits, choices

Mastering the specifics of buying before construction.

Buying off-plan (before or during construction) lets you customize and sometimes get a better price, but comes with specifics: staggered deposit payments, delivery timelines that can slip, and a final product you don't see until the end.

- Check the protection of your deposits (through the warranty).
- Clarify what's included vs optional (finishes, appliances).
- Allow a margin on the delivery date and its impact on your current home.
- Do a pre-delivery inspection to list the deficiencies to be fixed.

Buying off-plan carries its own risks: delivery timelines, choices locked in early, and a possible gap between the rendering and the result. Check the protection of your deposits, the late penalties and the builder's reputation. Do a pre-acceptance inspection and note all deficiencies in writing.

EMILIE'S TIP

Off-plan, anything not written down doesn't exist. Have every inclusion, finish and deadline specified in writing. The “model kitchen” isn't always the one that gets delivered.

CHAPTER

Checking an existing property

Reducing the risk on an existing property.

On existing homes, the professional inspection is your best ally. Target the age and condition of the major components (roof, windows, foundation, systems) and the Québec-specific points (clay soils, pyrite, French drain, buried tank, vermiculite).

Budget the renovations to expect within 5 years and factor them into your price decision. Old-world charm is worth it... when you buy with your eyes open.

On existing homes, target the costly items: roof, foundation, drain, plumbing, electrical, windows. Period charm can hide expensive code upgrades. The inspection and, if needed, targeted expert assessments turn uncertainty into a clear budget — and into negotiating leverage.

EMILIE'S TIP

On an existing property, ask yourself not “is it pretty?” but “what's going to cost me a lot in the next 5 years?” That's what buying smart is.

CHAPTER

Anticipating maintenance by age

Budgeting beyond the purchase price.

New or existing, every property has its spending profile. The purchase price is only the beginning:

- **New:** little maintenance in the early years, but sometimes finishing costs (landscaping, fencing, grading).
- **Existing:** charm and an often lower price, but components to watch (roof, windows, plumbing, electrical).

Set aside a **maintenance fund** every year: a common rule is to set aside a small percentage of the value each year for surprises.

Whatever the age, set aside a small percentage of the value each year for maintenance and surprises. A “cheap” house with a roof at end of life can cost more than a well-finished new one. The real price is the purchase price PLUS the maintenance to come.

EMILIE'S TIP

Always ask for the age of the major components: roof, heating, windows. A “cheap” house with a roof at end of life can cost more than a well-finished new one. The real price is price + maintenance.

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

Your next steps, concretely.

This week

1. List my priorities (warranty, location, space, budget).
2. Compare the 5-year total cost of a new option and an existing one.

Within 30 days

1. For new: check the warranty and inclusions in writing.
2. For existing: plan for the inspection and a renovation budget.

Next

1. Decide with Emilie the option most consistent with my life plan.

Depending on my choice

1. New/off-plan: check the GCR warranty, the deposit protection and the builder's reputation.
2. Existing: plan for the inspection and a realistic renovation budget.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- GCR: Residential Construction Warranty, the warranty plan for new homes in Quebec.
 - Off-plan purchase: buying before or during construction, with staggered deposits.
 - Pre-delivery inspection: a visit to list deficiencies before taking possession.
 - 5-year total cost: price + maintenance + energy + planned renovations.
 - Major defects: serious defects covered longer by the warranty.
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- GCR: residential construction warranty for eligible new homes.
 - Major defect: a defect compromising the soundness of the structure, covered longer.
 - Off-plan purchase: buying before/during construction, on the basis of the plans.
 - Pre-acceptance: a visit before delivery to record deficiencies.
 - Maintenance reserve: a sum set aside each year for work.

GOING FURTHER

Quiz — test your knowledge

1. A typical advantage of new is:

- A) Mature trees
- B) The warranty and energy efficiency
- C) An always-established neighbourhood
- D) No maintenance for life

2. A typical advantage of existing is:

- A) The new-home warranty
- B) An established location and sometimes more space for the price
- C) No renovation
- D) Guaranteed lower taxes

3. The GCR is there to:

- A) Set the price
- B) Protect the buyer of a new home (deposit, defects)
- C) Pay the Welcome Tax
- D) Insure the car

4. Before signing for new, you must:

- A) Ignore the warranty
- B) Require proof of the warranty's registration and read the coverage
- C) Pay cash
- D) Check nothing

5. Off-plan, a golden rule is:

- A) Rely on verbal promises
- B) Have inclusions, finishes and deadlines specified in writing
- C) Ask for nothing
- D) Pay everything upfront with no protection

6. A pre-delivery inspection is there to:

- A) Set the rent
- B) List the deficiencies to fix before taking possession
- C) Choose the colour
- D) Pay the notary

7. On existing homes, the best ally is:

- A) The photo on the listing
- B) The professional inspection
- C) The neighbour's opinion
- D) The weather

8. The right question on existing homes is:

- A) Is it pretty?
- B) What's going to cost a lot in 5 years?
- C) What colour?
- D) Is there a garden?

Answer key

- 1. **B** — Warranty and recent standards (ch. 1).
- 2. **B** — Established locations and charm (ch. 1).
- 3. **B** — It's the warranty plan for new homes (ch. 2).
- 4. **B** — You confirm the coverage before signing (ch. 2).
- 5. **B** — What isn't written doesn't exist (ch. 3).
- 6. **B** — You note the deficiencies to be fixed (ch. 3).
- 7. **B** — It targets the major components and Québec-specific points (ch. 4).
- 8. **B** — You budget the renovations to come (ch. 4).

Signé PAR Em

*Thank you for reading. May this guide help you
decide with confidence, with all the information
in hand.*

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